

LIVING THE GOOD LIFE

*POWER POINT SLIDE

** INSTRUCTIONS TO TECHNICIAN

TEXT: Ephesians 4:17-24 (NKJV) *“This I say, therefore, and testify in the Lord, that you should no longer walk as the rest of the Gentiles walk, in the futility of their mind, ¹⁸having their understanding darkened, being alienated from the life of God, because of the ignorance that is in them, because of the blindness of their heart; ¹⁹who, being past feeling, have given themselves over to lewdness, to work all uncleanness with greediness. ²⁰But you have not so learned Christ, ²¹if indeed you have heard Him and have been taught by Him, as the truth is in Jesus: ²²that you put off, concerning your former conduct, the old man which grows corrupt according to the deceitful lusts, ²³and be renewed in the spirit of your mind, ²⁴and that you put on the new man which was created according to God, in true righteousness and holiness.”*

INTRO: The Christian life was deliberately designed by an intelligent designer to aid the individual in living the best life possible. As Christians, we are not supposed to live like the rest of the culture. The Christian life was never designed to be culturally compatible but to be counter culture. This intentional lifestyle creates several things: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Gives the believer the advantage of living the best life possible...
- Causes the believer to live at peace with God and the inner man...
- Allows the believer to live at peace in all of his relationships...
- Affords the believer the opportunity to model a lifestyle which is counter-culture and much more desirable than the lifestyle offered by the world...

Thomas Jefferson said, *"In matters of style, swim with the current; in matters of principle, stand like a rock."*

In our text the Apostle Paul points to the drastic differences between believers and unbelievers:

(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Unbelievers walk in the emptiness of their own minds. Believers are supposed to be allowing their minds to be controlled by the power of the Christ life.
- Unbelievers live with their understanding darkened. Acts 28:27 (NKJV) ***"For the hearts of this people have grown dull. Their ears are hard of hearing, And their eyes they have closed, Lest they should see with their eyes and hear with their ears, Lest they should understand with their hearts and turn, So that I should heal them."*** They cannot understand what is wrong with their lifestyle while believers are walking in the light of a resurrected Lord. (We are stepping in the light!)

- **Unbelievers are alienated from the life of God.** This means they have no appreciation for the need to live a life above reproach. Believers are living the God life in the here-and-now and understand how important character and integrity are.
- **Unbelievers are past feeling.** This means they have become calloused; insensitive; unfeeling; or numb. Believers possess a renewed sensitivity toward God; other believers; and the world.
- **Unbelievers give themselves over to lasciviousness.** This is lewd living with no thought of how their conduct may appear to God or others. This is the utter drive to be filthy, unclean, sensual, and shameless. Believers walk in a heightened knowledge that God is recording our actions, as well as the awareness that others will respond positively or negatively to our lifestyle. *Zig Ziglar said, “Good values are easier caught than taught.”*
- **Unbelievers live lives of indulgence.** This is polluted behavior and immorality, unbridled lust turned loose. We are living in a culture gone wild! Believers are to be living clean, controlled lives, tempered with the love of God. Though we are to be living lives which are far more clean than that of the culture we are residing in, we cannot afford to adopt a separatist holier-than-thou attitude.
- **Unbelievers are controlled by greediness.** This is an overwhelming desire for more and more of

this world's goods. Greediness is the epitome of self centered behavior. Believers are called upon to prefer others ahead of self. We are also to be content with any situation we find ourselves in.

The good life cannot be attained through the things I have just talked about, the good life is a life lived for God and his purposes.

One of the great enemies of the believer is self-righteousness. Nate Larkin said, *"The greatest enemy to righteousness is not the sin I know I have, it's the righteousness I think I have"* *"All our righteousness is as filthy rags in the sight of God."*

So what if we are able to live a controlled life in the light of God; fellowshiping with God; sensitive to how God and others view our actions; and content with what God provides for us?

If this is the case in our lives, then we are living the good life! Aristotle said, *"Men acquire a particular quality by constantly acting in a particular way."*
(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)

Just because you are a Christian does not necessarily mean you are living the good life! Paul tells us there are three foundational stones to living the good life!

I. PUT OFF THE OLD MAN!

Ephesians 4:17-24 (NKJV) *“This I say, therefore, and testify in the Lord, that you should no longer walk as the rest of the Gentiles walk, in the futility of their mind, ¹⁸having their understanding darkened, being alienated from the life of God, because of the ignorance that is in them, because of the blindness of their heart; ¹⁹who, being past feeling, have given themselves over to lewdness, to work all uncleanness with greediness. ²⁰But you have not so learned Christ, ²¹if indeed you have heard Him and have been taught by Him, as the truth is in Jesus: ²²that you put off, concerning your former conduct, the old man which grows corrupt according to the deceitful lusts, ²³and be renewed in the spirit of your mind, ²⁴and that you put on the new man which was created according to God, in true righteousness and holiness.”* The old man spoken of here refers to the conduct of our life before we came into relationship with Jesus.

The reason we came into relationship with Jesus to begin with is because of illness and fatigue; we were sick and tired of what we had become. The old man is not what we want to perpetuate, we are in the process of becoming new creatures in Jesus.

It is true; when we come to Christ we become new creatures. 2 Corinthians 5:17 (LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE) (KJV) *“If any man be in Christ, he is a new creature: old things are passed away; behold, all things are become new.”* Galatians 6:15 (KJV) *“For in Christ Jesus neither circumcision*

availeth any thing, nor uncircumcision, but a new creature.

The idea of conversion carries with it an expectation of change. When a person becomes a Christian they are initiating a process of becoming Christ-like. When one asks Christ for forgiveness of the sins they have committed, the full weight of the power of the cross is brought to bear. Right then the power of the blood of Jesus cleanses one from all sin. 1 John 1:9 (NKJV) ***“If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.”*** His forgiveness allows us the start we so desperately need for living the good life!

When one asks Christ for forgiveness, one is as saved as he will ever be. It is at this point a new life begins. This initial event results in being born again! When one is born again a new life begins and the old life is suspended. [*Martin Luther King Jr. said, “The time is always right to do what is right.”*](#)

Jesus said to Nicodemus, ***“You must be born again.”*** Look at the discourse between Jesus and Nicodemus in the context in which it is written. [Notice the facts of Jesus conversation with Nicodemus in John 3:1-7:](#)
(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- [Nicodemus acknowledges that Jesus is from God](#), the proof of which is the miracles He performs. Verses 1 & 2 ***“There was a man of the Pharisees named Nicodemus, a ruler of the Jews. ²This man came to Jesus by night and***

said to Him, “Rabbi, we know that You are a teacher come from God; for no one can do these signs that You do unless God is with him.”.

- Jesus stuns Nicodemus by telling him one cannot “*See the Kingdom of God without being born again.*” Verse 3.
- Nicodemus immediately equates the phrase “*Born again*” with the natural birth, vs. 4 “*How can a man be born when he is old? Can he enter a second time into his mother’s womb and be born?*”
- Jesus responds to the Nicodemus’ question about whether his mother could birth him when he was a grown man, verse 5 “*Unless one is born of water and the Spirit, he cannot enter the kingdom of God.*” The natural birth is the first birth (The baby lives in a sack of water 9 months before being birthed) and the spiritual birth is the second birth, or being born again.

In order for the new man to emerge the old man must die! (LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)

Romans 6:11 (AMP) “*Even so consider yourselves also dead to sin and your relation to it broken, but alive to God living in unbroken fellowship with Him in Christ Jesus.*”

Rest assured the old man will not go peaceably! The old man will do everything in his power to escape, survive, revive, recur, reemerge, rematerialize, or to reinvent his self if necessary. The old man will do

everything in his power to come back to life because he wants to be in control and once he is permitted to resurface he will not stop until he is experiencing sin again! Rob Gilbert said, *“First we form habits, then they form us. Conquer your bad habits or they will conquer you.”* (LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE) The good life cannot be achieved without the cancellation of some bad habits!

Romans 6:12-13 (CEV) *“Don’t let sin rule your body. After all, your body is bound to die, so don’t obey its desires¹³ or let any part of it become a slave of evil. Give yourselves to God, as people who have been raised from death to life. Make every part of your body a slave that pleases God.”*

The old man is a force to be reckoned with but if one is to live the good life the old man must be killed and not allowed to revive its evil intentions in ones life. In our text for today the writer of Ephesians tells us, *“Put off, concerning your former conduct, the old man which grows corrupt according to the deceitful lusts.”* One version says to, *“Throw off the old man.”* This lets me know that I must put some effort in eliminating the old man and his influence. (Illustrate this) Jim Rohn said, *“We must all suffer one of two things: the pain of discipline or the pain of regret or disappointment.”* (LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL END OF SERVICE)

II. RENEW THE SPIRIT OF THE MIND!

[Ephesians 4:22-23](#) (NKJV) “*Put off, concerning your former conduct, the old man which grows corrupt according to the deceitful lusts,* ²³*and be renewed in the spirit of your mind.*” The world’s greatest battlefield is not in Iraq, Georgia or Afghanistan, it is in the mind. The battle against evil and lust is won or lost in the mind.

Our brain tells our elbow to bend so we can feed ourselves and the brain tells the left leg and the right leg when to respond so we can walk. The mind is such a sensitive thing that when it is allowed to feast on a thought process long enough it will just intuitively act upon what it has been allowed to think on.

When I was a young boy I would get in trouble for acting on thoughts I should have cast down and I would complain to my mom and tell her “*I couldn’t help it.*” My mother’s response was always, “*You cannot keep a bird from flying over your head but you can keep him from building a nest in your hair.*” This may be the most important truth I share with you today; [every individual is responsible for what we allow our minds permission to entertain. Whatever we allow our mind to entertain will eventually be acted upon:](#)

- [All liars plan their stories](#)
- [All thieves set themselves up to take things which do not belong to them](#)
- [All pedophiles have had problems with pornography](#)
- [All rapists have had a struggle with pornography](#)

- All adulterers and fornicators plan out their next conquest or rendezvous

This culture is coming apart at the seams because people have failed to use their heads for anything besides a hat rack! The human mind has a bent toward evil. You do not have to teach a child to:

- Lie
- Cheat
- Steal
- Misbehave

This culture reminds me of what the Bible has to say about the culture in Noah's day! [Genesis 6:5-8](#) (NKJV) ***"Then the LORD saw that the wickedness of man was great in the earth, and that every intent of the thoughts of his heart was only evil continually.*** ⁶*And the LORD was sorry that He had made man on the earth, and He was grieved in His heart.* ⁷*So the LORD said, "I will destroy man whom I have created from the face of the earth, both man and beast, creeping thing and birds of the air, for I am sorry that I have made them."* ⁸*But Noah found grace in the eyes of the LORD."* Proverbs 6:12-15 (NKJV) ***"A worthless person, a wicked man, Walks with a perverse mouth; ¹³ He winks with his eyes, He shuffles his feet, He points with his fingers; ¹⁴ Perversity is in his heart, He devises evil continually, He sows discord. ¹⁵ Therefore his calamity shall come suddenly; Suddenly he shall be broken without remedy."*** This is a perfect picture of [the difficulties we face in the current:](#)

- Wickedness in high places has become the norm
- Scandal in religious circles is no big surprise
- Multiple marriages are the rule rather than the exception
- Shacking up has become as common as getting married
- Single parenting is more normal than mom and dad being under the same roof
- Abortion has been legalized
- Homosexuality has become main stream

The result is a culture teetering on the brink of collapse! Proverbs 14:34 (NKJV)

“Righteousness exalts a nation, But sin is a reproach to any people.” Roe versus Wade has been responsible for the death of forty six million babies since 1973! Think about the following annual **abortion statistics**:

Gestational Age	Percentage	Yearly Total
Less than 9 weeks	57.9%	752,700
9-10 weeks	20.3%	263,900
11-12 weeks	10.2%	132,600
13-15 weeks	6.2%	80,600
16-20 weeks	4.3%	55,900
21+ weeks	1.5%	19,500

It is believed that [as many as 10% of Americans are homosexual!](#) I know there are those who would say “*sin is sin and there are no degrees of sin!*” I agree, but I can assure you there are degrees of consequences! If you lie to someone there are consequences but if you go out and have a one night stand with someone who has HIV Aids there are different consequences! I recently had a conversation with a young person about this very thing and I made this comment, “*Your generation will reap the negative consequences of abortion and homosexual activity.*

[Roe Verses Wade has been responsible for the aborting of forty six million babies since 1973](#) and the homosexual agenda has become a priority. As a result, pro-creation within these relationships are impossible! If the population of the United States of America is three hundred five million (According to the U. S. Census Bureau) and 10% are homosexual, this means that [because of homosexuality, fifteen million American couples will not pro create!](#) You add fifteen million couples not pro-creating to forty six million abortions and what you soon conclude is that the population is growing older at a much faster rate than it is replenishing itself. The first child legally aborted in this country would now be thirty five years old and in the prime of its wage earning potential. That child, along with forty six million others like it have been murdered and fifteen million couples are not pro creating which means that the retirees will soon outnumber the wage earners! [The next generation will be forced to care for or eliminate their](#)

elderly parents because the government will not have the revenues necessary to take care of them. If I do not miss my guess by the time the next generation is saddled with the responsibility of caring for their elderly relatives, abortion will not only be in vogue, but euthanasia will be viewed as a way of dealing with the problem of the elderly!”

The projections of an aging culture being circulated from [the United States Government](#) are staggering: The number of persons aged sixty five years is expected to increase from approximately thirty five million in 2000 to an estimated seventy one million in 2030! The number of persons aged eighty years is expected to increase from nine million three hundred thousand in 2000 to nineteen million five hundred thousand in 2030. Social Security is already in trouble and [the next twenty two years will add forty six million additional benefit seekers to an already overtaxed, under funded Social Security system!](#) It does not take a mathematician to figure out a collapse is in the offing!

America will pay dearly for its sin! Solomon was right; ***“Righteousness exalts a nation, But sin is a reproach to any people.”***

[The government](#) cannot pass enough laws to legislate morality because it cannot control the thought process of its citizens but it [can and should enact laws which protect life!](#) Thomas Jefferson said, “Democracy cannot control people who cannot control themselves.”

It is not the responsibility of government to control our thought process; this is the responsibility of each individual. Remember, garbage in, garbage out! (Illustrate this by packing a trash can full of paper then pouring it out on the floor!)

Taking charge of our thought process involves renewing our minds. How can this be accomplished?

- By making a conscious decision concerning what I will allow my mind to think on
- By making a conscious decision concerning what I will not allow my mind to think on
- By casting down any imagination that is not wholesome
- By replacing all wicked thoughts with wholesome thoughts

Phillippians 4:6-8 (KJV) ***“Be careful for nothing; but in every thing by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known unto God. ⁷And the peace of God, which passeth all understanding, shall keep your hearts and minds through Christ Jesus. ⁸Finally, brethren, whatsoever things are true, whatsoever things are honest, whatsoever things are just, whatsoever things are pure, whatsoever things are lovely, whatsoever things are of good report; if there be any virtue, and if there be any praise, think on these things.”***

We must be constantly renewing our mind because of the culture we live in and the effect sin has on our

mind. The enemy is constantly playing mind games on the believer.

The believer is to live a transformed life. This means every day, he is to renew his mind and allow God to transform his thought process. This process is made easier through:

- Daily prayer
- Systematically reading the Scriptures
- Meditating upon the things of God
- Thinking on good things
- Being careful about associations which draw us into thoughts which are not wholesome

If we are going to be successful living the good life we must renew the spirit of our mind!

III. PUT ON THE NEW MAN!

Ephesians 4:22-24 (NKJV) *“Put off, concerning your former conduct, the old man which grows corrupt according to the deceitful lusts,²³ and be renewed in the spirit of your mind,²⁴ and that you put on the new man which was created according to God, in true righteousness and holiness.”*

In this series we have learned that if we are going to be successful we must; put off the old man; renew the spirit of our mind; and now we must put on the new man. We have talked about being born again, this is not the end it is the beginning of a wonderful new process of life. Once we are born again God wants to take us on an exciting new journey.

This Journey involves several things:

Water Baptism (THE EXAMPLE AND COMMAND OF JESUS TO BE BAPTISED)

Holy Spirit Baptism (IT IS EXPEDIENT – THESE WORKS AND GREATER)

Developing a network of Christian Friends

A process of discipleship (MAKE DISCIPLES, TEACHING THEM...)

Maintaining enough contacts in the world to witness to our old friends (ACTS 1:8)

four steps of human and spiritual development:

- **The baby stage...** A baby thinks only of self, and if denied it will raise a ruckus. It seeks its own way. Its feelings are easily hurt, and it is often jealous. It cries but never sings. It tries to talk but never makes sense. A baby loves to be served but it never serves. It drinks milk and cannot digest solid foods.
- **The little child stage...** Children are often untruthful, envious, and cruel. If rebuked they become martyrs. If crossed they become resentful and often make a scene. They are talebearers repeating everything they hear (In adults it is known as gossip). They are given to emotional outbursts and are easily offended. They love praise and will accept it from any source. They seek only the things that appeal to self.
- **The young adult stage...** They are strong and agile and well able to overcome most any enemy. They have vision and faith for the future, along with the courage and tenacity to tackle it. They are in preparation for the productive years of their lives.
- **The parent stage...** They have peace with God; rejoice in their children; have learned to be content with the circumstances; know the source of real strength; do not brood over the past but look with faith to the future; know that all things work together for good; they enjoy life now and look expectantly to eternal life.

Putting on the new man and living the good life involves a process of Christian maturity. (GROW IN GRACE) (THAT YE BE NO MORE CHILDREN)

The new man is the man who has been regenerated and reborn.

- He is in fellowship with God.
- He is obedient to his will.
- He is devoted to God's service.

AMEN!